message sheet were made known to him, he said firmly that he had issued no such orders.

Speaking to both the chief and the army commander, the DMO said: ‘We could never face the nation if 12,000 troops, supported by artillery and mortars and stocked for battle, ran away without even facing the enemy. In my opinion, 4th Division is in a position to withstand an attack in strength by the Chinese.’

After some discussion, the COAS ordered that the withdrawal order be cancelled.

At that point, the original message allowing 4 Division to withdraw had not been sent as it was still being encoded. Accordingly, a new signal with Kaul’s signature was drafted and dispatched that ordered 4 Division ‘to remain at Se-la and to fight it out to the best of its ability and withdraw only if its position became untenable’.

62 BRIGADE HQ (17 NOVEMBER - EVENING)

In an interview more than two decades later, Anant Pathania said he never ‘ordered’ Hoshiar Singh to withdraw from Se-la. Instead, Pathania claimed, he only ‘suggested’ to Hoshiar Singh that he prepare a ‘withdrawal plan’ for the brigade for the night of 17-18 November. This bizarre attempt to pass the buck to his subordinate officer (posthumously) underlines the dangerous state of mind and the guile of a desperate man who has lost his will to fight but is compelled to keep up appearances nevertheless.

On the other hand, there was Hoshiar Singh, quite willing to fight it out at Se-la despite the near arctic conditions at the top of the pass and his own tactical shortcomings. Though he had fallen into the Chinese trap and sent out the composite 1 Sikh and 2 Sikh LI patrol earlier with disastrous consequences, he had mentally prepared himself and the brigade to fight and not once had he shown signs of wavering. For Pathania to have put the seeds of doubt in Hoshiar’s Singh’s mind by asserting that ‘he could not guarantee’ air supply was indeed a great betrayal. Although the Indian Air Force had done a tremendous job airlifting supplies to Senge to sustain the Se-la brigade, this was not a guarantee anyone could give. Besides, neither Anant Pathania nor HQ 4 Division had anything to do with the air drops other than forward the logistical requirements. For air supply to have become a reason for abandoning Se-la was indeed most unfortunate, and as